

THE “OTHER” JOBS IN THE VOC

A Critical Approach Towards the Enriched VOC Dataset

Esther Chan
Mark Waterreus
Veronica Rossi



Introduction: the VOC 1602 - 1799

- Remembered as the first modern corporation, many studies have researched its evolution concluding that its trajectory reflected a western response to tackle financial concerns.
- Its history intertwines with European dynamics and colonial expansion favored by European governments.
- → In fact, it is also known for its relevant role in accomplishing Dutch colonial efforts.
- The **Dutch East India Company's 18th-Century Workforce: an Enriched Data Collection** is a detailed account of workers hired by the VOC and their salaries.

Research Intention

Upon inspecting the dataset, we looked into specific jobs under the dataset and found confusion within the job category “other”. This job category includes a vast variety of professions, such as craftsmen, musicians, clergymen, and even the council of justice. Given the difference in nature and wage level of these jobs, we are curious in the intentions and implications behind such categorisation.

Research Question

What is the logic behind the job categorisation in the VOC dataset, and does the categorisation “other” work in concealing **these jobs’ contribution to the VOC’s imperial enterprise**, and instead **undermines them as purely commercial**? Does the VOC dataset illustrate this or help in sustaining this belief?

Citations

- Barendregt, Bart A., and Els Bogaerts. Recollecting Resonances: Indonesian-Dutch Musical Encounters. Southeast Asia Mediated 4. Brill, 2014. P112)
- Parker, Charles H. “The Calvinist Conquest.” Edited by Sam Haselby. aeon, 2022. <https://aeon.co/essays/the-legacies-of-calvinism-in-the-dutch-empire>.
- Trumpeting the VOC’s Success.” Archaeology, artefacts and archives. Accessed May 18, 2026. https://visit.museum.wa.gov.au/batavia-ebook-2022-web/Batavia_ENG_01-62.xhtml.
- Valeri, Mark. “Global Calvinism: Conversion and Commerce in the Dutch Empire, 1600–1800, by Charles H. Parker.” Church History and Religious Culture 104, no. 1 (2024): 140–42.

Data Analysis

The following graphs visualise the historical mobility and wage level of the workers categorised under the domain “other”. The original data has many gaps and inconsistencies, even while it has been extensively curated and improved by the dataset-creators. These gaps can be mitigated to some extent by incorporating other, external, data sources.

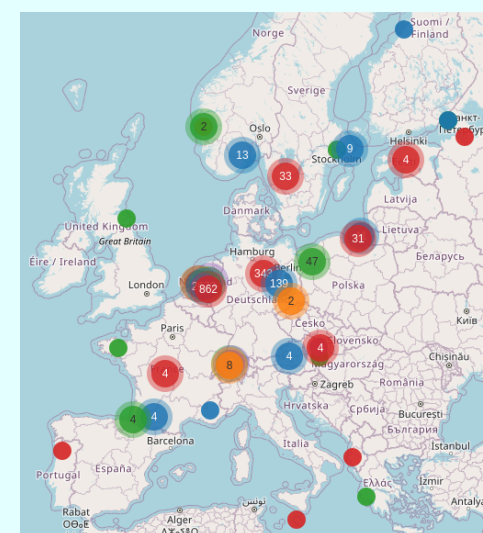


Fig.1. Place of origin of the recorded VOC workers in the category “Other”

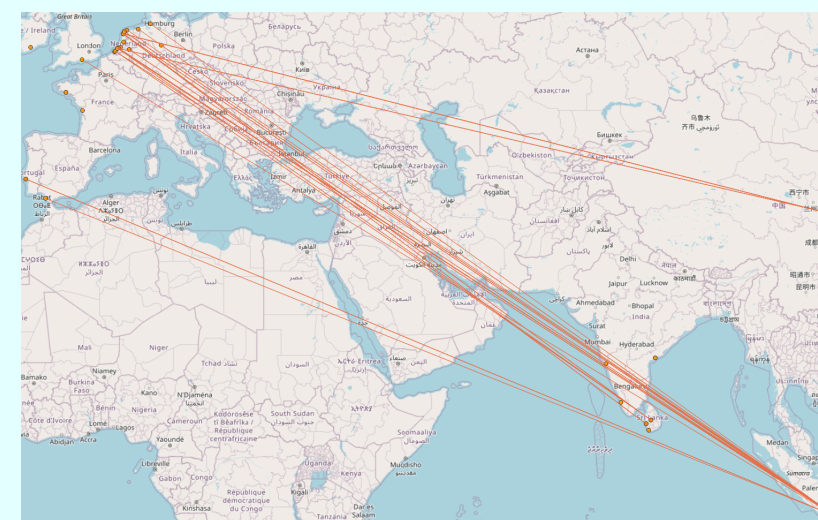


Fig.2. Routes taken by the workers in the category “Other”, including starting point and destination

Fig.1 shows that the workforce in the category “other” mainly comes from the Netherlands and Poland. Although the proportion taken up by this job category is significantly lower than other categories, secondary research suggests that they brought heavy impacts on the destinations’ culture, religion, society and infrastructure.

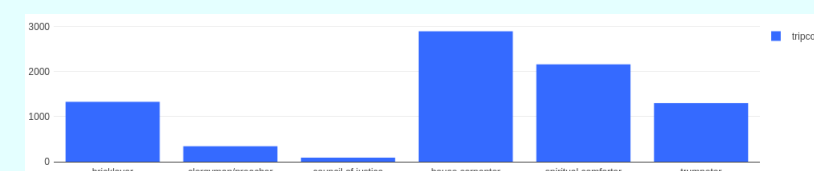


Fig.4. Trip counts of the workers

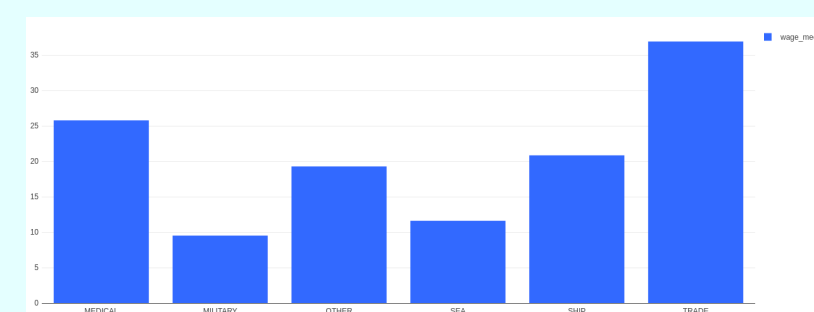


Fig.5. Wage median distribution by job categories

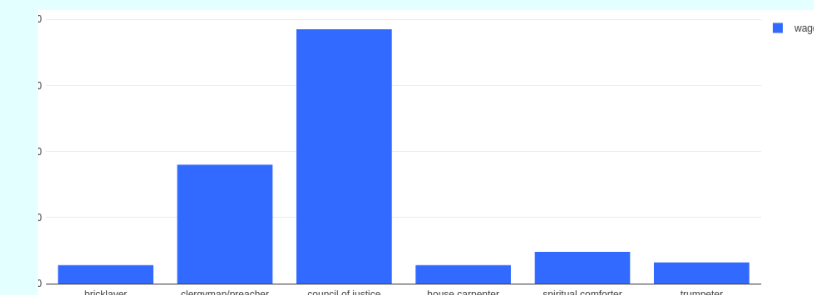


Fig.6. Wage median distribution by jobs in the category “Other”

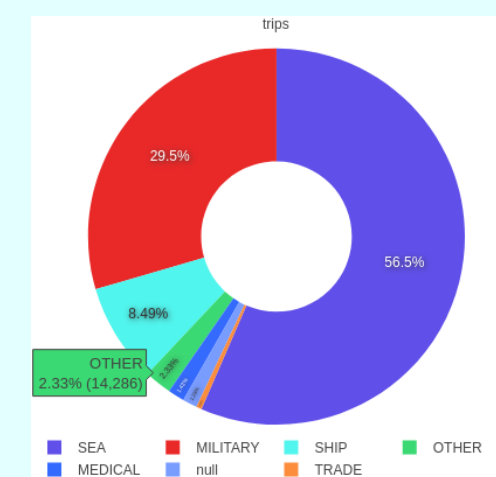


Fig.3. Pie chart showing trips taken by each job category

Fig.4 suggests that musicians and religious workers, including both clergymen and spiritual comforters, had participated in quite a significant number of trips.

Fig.5 shows the variation in wage level by median between different jobs categories. Despite that the workforce took up a small proportion, the wage median of “Other” is the 4th highest.

Fig.6 further shows that the wage median of clergymen and spiritual comforters were the highest after council of justice, suggesting how worthy they were to the VOC.

Clergymen



VOC: “vehicles for Calvinist missions to indigenous people” (Valeri 2024)

- their missions worked better where the trading companies flourished, vice versa (Valeri 2024)

Clergymen: highly educated people -> relevant on ships for non-religious reasons

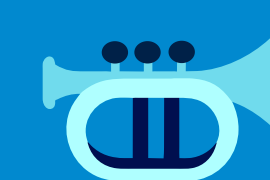
From 1605 to 1799: 1,000 Calvinist pastors joined the VOC
→ converted people in Americas, Africa and Asia
→ Religion’s entanglement with imperial & commercial movements (Parker 2022)

Musicians



Drummers

- Tamburu drum mainly played during military processions
- **Sultan of Buton:** inspired by the tamburu drums
- -> decides to mimic the European drumming patterns (Batavia Discovery and Excavation, 2022)



Trumpeters

- Assistants for the ship’s captain
- Communication with indigenous leaders
- Signal senders (directions, arrival, departure...) (Barendregt, Bart A., and Els Bogaerts, 2014)

Conclusion

Due to time constraints and the limitation of applicable data, the data visualisations can help us as a starting point for further research. Our research questions whether the job categorisation in the enriched VOC dataset, specifically the category “other”, is appropriate. The VOC has been propagated as a commercial organisation rather than an imperial enterprise in Dutch historical narratives. With this in mind, the vagueness and innocuousness implied by the word “other” could work in conveying the colonial impacts brought by these workers.